

Case Study: Ireland: Diaspora Strategy

[Home](#) [Case Studies](#)

Sources:

- Document: [Notes on Ireland Diaspora Strategy.docx](#)
- Book: [Migrations: Ireland in a Global World](#), Gilmartin, Mary, and Allen White, Manchester University Press, 2013

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Ecosystem: Key Players

- **Funds:**
 - The Ireland Funds (IF) - 300M
 - International Fund for Ireland (IFI) - 850M
 - Atlantic Philanthropies (AP) - 1.2B
- **Agencies:**
 - The Industrial Development Agency (14 offices)
 - Enterprise Ireland (31 offices) - supports 60 business networks and 30k members
- **Networks & Federations:**
 - Irish Technology Leadership Group (ITLG) - Silicon Valley
 - Techlink UK
 - Biolink Ireland USA
 - Global Irish Network
 - Global Irish Economic Forum
 - National Solidarity Diaspora Bond
 - Emigrant Support Programme
 - Crosscare Migrant Project
 - Irish Network of Great Britain
 - Emigrant Advice Network

Executive Summary

Despite being varied and complex, it is often assumed that a strong relationship has prevailed between the Irish diaspora and Ireland, with the diaspora operating transnationally, bequeathing a flow of various exchanges (e.g. information, goods, money, tourist visits, political will) between diaspora members and family and social, cultural, economic and political institutions in Ireland.

It is possible to identify up to **ten transnational practices through which diasporic populations impact upon the development of sending states:**

1. Diaspora advocacy and diplomacy - advocates, activists, agitators and ambassadors within diasporic communities can exploit their knowledge, contacts, linguistic skills and cultural insights to promote peace and security in their homelands and to enhance the strategic, diplomatic and foreign policy objectives of homelands.

2. Diaspora capital markets - diaspora members can fuel capital markets (portfolio investment) through holding deposit accounts, securitizing remittance flows, providing transnational loans to diaspora groupings, buying diaspora bonds and supporting diaspora mutual funds

3. Diaspora direct investment - diaspora members can invest in homelands as senior executives in transnational corporations, venture capitalists, investors and by outsourcing contracts to small and medium-sized enterprises in countries of origin

4. Diaspora knowledge networks - diaspora can assist companies in sending countries by providing knowledge and contacts; sharing knowledge; mentoring organizations; training talented colleagues; and joining think-tanks, consultation groups and advisory councils

5. Diaspora philanthropy*** - diasporic communities can provide private and voluntary donations for charitable and public good through such vehicles as private and voluntary organizations, religious organizations, corporations, foundations, volunteer citizens, and university and college alumni associations

6. Diaspora remittances - diasporic remittance flows entail private or person to-person transfers from migrant workers to recipients in the worker's country of origin

7. Diaspora return migration - diasporic populations can promote bilateral and multilateral agreements to restrict recruitment from especially vulnerable and at-risk countries; increase accountability among recruitment specialists and employers; establish protocols for the treatment of foreign workers; and facilitate return migration

8. Diaspora corps/volunteer schemes - diaspora groupings can establish volunteering schemes to promote short-term assistance in countries of origin by skilled diaspora volunteers and youth diaspora volunteers, especially in relation to the support of vulnerable populations, the provision of skills that are in short supply, and to assist in the administration of aid, not least following a natural or a human induced disaster

9. Diaspora tourism - diaspora visits to homelands provide an important source of revenue and foreign currency, incorporating: medical tourism, business-related tourism, heritage (or 'roots') tourism, exposure or 'birthright' tours, education tourism, VIP tours and peak experience tours (one that provides people with a deep emotional experience by bringing them to ancestral homes)

10. Diaspora human capital effects - the prospect of joining the ranks of sometimes more wealthy diaspora can result in a pre-departure boost in the human capital of sending states: migrants prepare for a potential exit by upgrading their competencies and skill set and increasing their likelihood of securing a relocation to a more developed labor market

- Ireland has a very poorly developed indigenous philanthropic landscape, but has been successful in cultivating philanthropy in the diaspora. **The Ireland Funds**, **International Fund for Ireland (IFI)**, and **Atlantic Philanthropies (AP)** are prime examples. *Over the past thirty years, the Ireland Funds have raised more than €300 million to be spent on projects in Ireland, IFI more than €850 million and AP more than €1.2 billion.* In the main, these funds have been targeted at social disadvantage, education and welfare, and supporting community development and local economic initiatives with the aim of increasing social and economic capital.
- During the **years of the Celtic Tiger**, given the strength of the Irish economy and the lure of well-paid jobs, proactive programs were perhaps not needed to entice Irish people to return to Ireland. But nevertheless public and privately funded recruitment fairs were held in key diaspora centers, in part in an effort to ease bottlenecks in **key labour markets**.
- More recently, the Irish state has turned its attention to business networks, and in particular diaspora knowledge networks. The Irish government has invested heavily and successfully in the promotion of inward investment and in building business partnerships with the Irish diaspora globally.

- **The Industrial Development Agency**, with fourteen offices outside of Ireland, is responsible for the attraction and development of foreign investment in Ireland. *While it targets any company which might potentially locate in Ireland it has a successful track record of recruiting businesses owned and/or run by Irish or Irish-descent entrepreneurs and managers.*

Enterprise Ireland, with thirty-one offices outside of Ireland, is the state agency responsible for the development and promotion of the Irish business sector and in assisting international companies and entrepreneurs who are searching for Irish suppliers or are interested in investing in Irish companies. At present, **Enterprise Ireland supports, through in-kind or financial aid, over sixty Irish business networks around the world with over 30,000 members.**

These networks are used to support the work of members whether they are located in Ireland or not. **Irish Technology Leadership Group (ITLG)**, comprising **Irish people in senior positions in the high-tech world in Silicon Valley, who are seeking to invest in Irish companies, partly because they want to make a contribution to promoting Ireland but also because they see this initiative as a good and profitable enterprise for their members as well.** The ITLG comes closest to mimicking the work of the Chinese, Indian and Taiwanese diaspora much vaunted work on diasporas in Silicon Valley, California.

- Unlike other countries such as Scotland and Chile, which have placed emphasis on developing a single elite business network of high-level achievers among the diaspora, **Ireland has adopted a much more plural approach that aims to foster a number of business networks and to develop a wide base of contacts and expertise. Some of these, such as Techlink UK and Biolink Ireland USA, were initially seeded by Enterprise Ireland and others were started by the diaspora.** In the main, networks are owned and run by their members and function as social/business networking sites, many of whom also organize regular face-to-face meetings
- There are numerous *Irish business forums and chambers of commerce*. For example, the Asia Pacific Business forum links eleven Irish business groups in the Asia Pacific and the Gulf to facilitate an exchange of ideas and resources and to leverage reputation and connections, while the **Irish Chamber of Commerce USA is a transnational economic network with thirteen chapters across the USA.**
- The **Ireland Funds** events also provide an important business networking function. **The breadth and depth of these business networks**, given the size of Ireland, are exceptional, although there are still many possibilities for expansion, especially with respect to both generalist and specialist networks
- **Another strategy is to look at competitive assets such as pools of talent overseas as potential critical brokers of success.** In September 2009, the then Minister for Foreign Affairs, Mr. Micheal Martin T.D., convened the first Global Irish Economic Forum which brought together nearly 250 of the most influential Irish diasporians from around the world to explore how the Irish diaspora might contribute to crisis management and economic recovery and how Ireland might create a more strategic relationship with its diaspora. **This has led to the creation of the Global Irish Network comprising 300 Irish diasporic 'thought leaders' from thirty-seven countries.**
- A series of 'regional meetings' of this network are held on an ongoing basis, and the second **Global Irish Economic Forum** was held in October 2011. Following the creation of this network projects that have been instituted include the establishment of a **National Solidarity Diaspora Bond**, the opening of a New Arts Centre in New York, the advancement of a plan to set up a new university for the performing arts in Ireland, the launch of a major diaspora return tourism initiative, 'the Gathering', scheduled for 2013, and the *introduction of a student intern scheme to facilitate up to 2000 interns to work for a period with companies in Asia (including China, India, Singapore and South Korea)*
- *The development of broad-based information portals for the diaspora has been left to independent organizations to develop, although some receive finance and advice from government departments.* Through the **Emigrant Support Programme**, for example, funding has been allocated to support a number of online information services, including **Crosscare Migrant Project** (www.migrantproject.ie), the **Irish Network of Great Britain** (www.in-gb.co.uk) and, before it discontinued operations, the **Emigrant Advice Network** (www.ean.ie).

Conclusions:

We believe that the key elements for the Irish Diaspora success are:

- the size of the ecosystem of organizations forming it and support each other
- the breadth and depth of its networks, and
- the financial and institutional support offered by the Irish state for the diaspora to self-organize

To date the most distinctive lesson that Ireland might offer to the developing global debate on international best practice is the importance of resisting overly muscular strategies and of working to support the self-organization of the diaspora.